

- **Research shows that** women who receive continuous emotional and physical encouragement during labor are less likely to need pain relief or medical intervention such as an [epidural](#), [assisted birth](#), or [Cesarean](#), and should experience a shorter labor.
- **Women who feel their birth partner** was supportive are more likely to view their birth in a positive light, and to take to motherhood and breastfeeding easily, and are less prone to postpartum depression.
- **Your birth partner** doesn't have to be the baby's father (although he may be there as well); in fact, studies indicate that a woman may do the job better. A close female friend who's had her own children could be ideal; your mom is another option.
- **You could consider** hiring a [doula](#).